

Causes Restless legs syndrome is frequently triggered or aggravated by pregnancy. The cause is unknown, but some studies indicate that it might be related to low iron levels. Many sufferers have a family history of the condition.

What to do Talk to your doctor about having a full blood count to check your iron levels. Some women find it helpful to exercise or stretch their legs, to use hot or cold compresses, or to have a leg massage. If the condition occurs for the first time in pregnancy, there is a very good chance that it will disappear after the baby is born.

Carpal tunnel syndrome The carpal tunnel is a small tunnel in the wrist through which nerves run from your forearm into your hands and fingers. Carpal tunnel syndrome occurs when the nerves are compressed, resulting in tingling and pain in the fingers, which is often worse at night. In severe cases, there may be considerable discomfort and a reduced grip. It is most likely in the second and third trimesters.

Causes Carpal tunnel syndrome is caused by pressure on nerves running through the tunnel due to swelling of surrounding tissues. During pregnancy, swelling in the hands and feet is common as a result of the extra fluid and blood volume.

What to do Talk to your doctor. You may be referred to a physical therapist for treatment, who will recommend specific exercises to help relieve the discomfort. You may also be advised to wear a lightweight splint to support the wrists. Carpal tunnel syndrome usually disappears after the birth, but if it persists, a simple operation can be carried out.

Urinary and vaginal problems

Having an increased amount of vaginal discharge during pregnancy is normal. However, if the discharge is creamy and thick, and you also have some soreness and itching, you may have a yeast infection. If you have a vaginal discharge that has a fishy odor, particularly after having sex, you may have bacterial vaginosis (BV), a common cause of vaginal discharge. It has been associated with an increased risk of premature labor but usually only in those women who are at risk of premature labor for other reasons.

Causes Both yeast and BV occur when the acidity of the vagina drops, which is common in pregnancy. BV is caused by a lack of lactobacilli (good bacteria) and yeast is caused by a fungus called *Candida albicans*.

What to do Avoid washing your vagina with strongly scented soaps and gels. Go see your doctor for advice.

Stress incontinence

You will pass small amounts of urine unintentionally, particularly when you are coughing, sneezing, or laughing, and when you are exercising or lifting heavy objects. It is most common in the last trimester.

Causes The pelvic-floor muscles are additionally strained during pregnancy and are also affected by hormonal changes. Therefore, any increase in abdominal pressure may result in leakage of urine.

What to do Practicing [pelvic floor exercises](#) regularly should help. Empty your bladder without delay whenever you need to. Wear a sanitary pad for additional reassurance.

Urinary-tract infections (UTIs) During pregnancy, you are more susceptible to UTIs. Most commonly, they are confined to the bladder and known as cystitis. Symptoms include a frequent, urgent need to urinate and a painful burning sensation when urinating; there may be some blood in your urine. Occasionally, an infection can travel to the kidneys. In this case, you may also have pain in your lower back on one side, a high temperature, and you may feel nauseated or vomit. Sometimes there are no symptoms. Prompt treatment of UTIs is especially important because if an infection reaches the kidneys, it can trigger early labor.